

An Autistic Student in Your Secondary-School Class

For secondary-school teachers, form tutors & heads of year — supporting an autistic teenager (roughly ages 12–18).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a student's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Secondary school multiplies the load: changing rooms every lesson, new peer hierarchies, puberty, exams, and corridors and dining halls that are "hell for many monotropic kids — even though a lot of us love learning." This is the **peak age for anxiety, depression and burnout**, and many autistic teens (especially girls and marginalised genders) are **first identified only in crisis**. Resistance at changeover is a cognitive-cost problem, not defiance; their intense interests are a route to engagement and identity, not a distraction.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Deep interest; resists other work	A passion and the best bridge to the curriculum — not a distraction
"Defiant" at transitions; school refusal	Autistic inertia + overwhelm — changing track costs real energy
Meltdown or withdrawal in corridors, at break or lunch	Unstructured, noisy time is often the hardest part of the day
"Fine" in class, then a crisis	Heavy masking ; the cost is paid later
Slow to answer; takes things literally; "rude"	Single-channel, literal communication + processing time

Try this

- **Use the special interest as a bridge** to the subject — projects, reading, research and assessment *through* it.
- **Predictability lowers the load**: visible timetable, seating plan, warnings before changes, a reliable calm space and a named adult.
- **Give instructions in writing**, one thing at a time, with reasons; allow processing time.
- **Protect unstructured time** — a lunch club, library job or quiet space is often the difference between coping and crisis.
- **Take their inner life seriously** — ask directly, literally, about workload, anxiety and friendships; believe them.

Avoid this

- Using the interest only as a reward to withhold, or insisting on eye contact/stillness.
- Piling on verbal instructions, surprise changes, or forced group work without preparation.
- Reading a masked, compliant lesson as "they're fine," or a shutdown as refusal.

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** / “**regression**” — a sudden drop in skills usually means *overwhelm*; respond by **reducing demands and restoring rest and interests**, not pushing harder. Liaise with **parents, the SENCO/SEND lead** and any autism outreach team. **Screen for anxiety, depression and suicidality** and flag bullying early — high-quality friendship is powerfully protective.

If the student is a girl or marginalised gender

Camouflaging peaks here; the quiet, “anxious perfectionist” is often a missed autistic student. Take subtle differences and parental concern seriously, and watch for private collapse behind a competent surface.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 3), the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.3) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual student.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2019, *Monotropism at School*; 2023); Leatherland (2019, secondary school); Wood (2019, interests & inclusion); Edgar (2024, regression/burnout); Bradley et al. (2021, camouflaging). Full citations are in the source drafts.